

Ghosts of decades past

First up, a very happy and prosperous new year! A lot of you have been reading Digit for most of the last decade. It was an exciting 10 years, to say the least, and we've been humbled by the extent of your support. Digit looks forward to keeping you at the forefront of IT, and helping you navigate the often overwhelming world of technology for this new decade as well.

Last year, our publishing director encouraged you to "build something", and we've been trying our best to help you with articles that showed you how to build various things – mobile apps, little electronic gadgets, robots, super computers, and more...

We're obviously going to continue to do that, based on your positive feedback, but we're also going to raise the bar a little. Our goal at Digit has always been to leave lasting impressions by helping our readers do more with technology, and part of this, I think is to push you to think bigger.

Our billionaire story in this issue is along those lines... which brings a quote to mind: A friend once told me, "You have a 50 per cent chance of becoming a billionaire!" "How so?" I asked. "Either you will, or you won't. 50:50." he replied. Sounds like childish banter, I know, but I think it's all about self belief at times.

We Indians have got all the ingredients needed to achieve this, and although most of us Digit readers will never be filthy rich, I certainly believe that *some* of us will. What's important, in my humble opinion, is innovative thinking, the willingness to take risks and following our instincts.

What we need to stop doing, however, is being me-toos. Take this month's Tablet PC test for instance. Although we had a lot of brands participate, it became very obvious, very quickly, that there were really only a handful of unique devices out there. Most people seem to be heading off to the east, finding mass produced tablets and just re-branding and selling them here in India. I expect to see even more brands pop-up in 2011, and considering that we already have more brands than distinct tablet configurations, it's going to be a nightmare to sort through.

The tablets that stand out from the crowd are those from the bigger brands. An expected

outcome, we all assume. Sure, the easy way out is to re-brand existing hardware and not spend any money on development, but just because it's easier doesn't make it right.

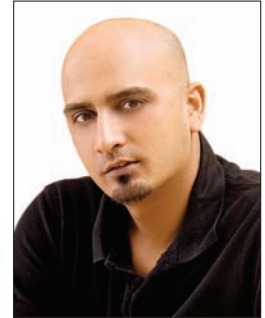
It's also easy to give up because you don't have the budgets that giants like Apple and Samsung have at their disposal, but then that's exactly what it's all about, isn't it?

Facebook came about at a time when the giants – Google, Microsoft and Yahoo! – were going hammer and tongs at each other in the quest for web dominance. If a certain college coder had thought, "What's the point? I can't compete with guys who have billion dollar budgets", we'd have no Facebook today. Not that it would matter, because someone else would make something else that would capture our attention and our clicks, and become a billionaire in the process...

In school, I remember a teacher once telling my class, "Aim for the the stars, and you'll reach the sky... aim for the sky, and you'll reach the treetops... aim for the treetops, and you'll never get your f%*\$ing a%\$e of the ground!"

It's actually a pretty common saying, but I remember this version, expletives and all, because the teacher in question was one of those colourful characters that you will remember for life. The message was simple though, think big, and don't be afraid to dream.

Think about it. We tend to remember the colourful characters from our past, and forget the ones who were stereotypical. Similarly, we need to think that way about our careers, and use our skills to be colourful, and stand out from the crowds. India needs to forget the ghosts of decades past, throw accepted logic out the window and start on the journey we're all destined for. Lets build products, services and software that we'll be remembered for, and in the process build an IT empire the world will truly respect, instead of chasing the quick bucks like we tend to. 



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
editor@thinkdigit.com

"Aim for the the stars, and you'll reach the sky... aim for the sky, and you'll reach the treetops... aim for the treetops, and you'll never get your f%*\$ing a%\$e of the ground!"

Liked or hated the views in this column? Write in to express your own opinions and ideas.